Appendix: A Note on the Chinese Script

Nothing marks China as a unique culture more than its language and script. Chinese has no alphabet. It is composed of ideograms, which have their origin in pictographs used in ancient times for divination. These pictographs were originally simplified images of actual objects which, over an extended period of time, became stylized into what we now call characters.

The pictographic script emerged in the ancient Shang dynasty more than three centuries ago and is found on ‘oracle bones’. These were tortoise shells or scapula bones of animals such as sheep or cattle. Holes were made in them, and then they were placed in a sacrificial fire. These holes then cracked the bones in different directions, indicating different predictions. These predictions were recorded on the bones in the form of pictographs which, by the time of the Han dynasty, had already evolved into a more complex ideographic script but with the original image still apparent in some instances. Each character may have been pronounced in different ways in different dialects, but the meaning of each remained generally uniform. This is what created, in time, a generally unified literary culture.